

Chapter 104-1

The immersive experience of escape rooms comes from the realistic set designs and live NPCs—whether solving puzzles or completing tasks, everything makes you feel like you're truly there.

Liang Shi had come to play because her former assistant had enthusiastically recommended it, saying the immersive escape room experience was excellent, that it scared her heart into pounding, but it was especially good for releasing stress.

As a result, Sister Wang had glared at her at the time and asked coldly, "What stress do you have?"

Assistant Xiao Bai: "....."

Xiao Bai, whose scalp went numb from Sister Wang's gaze, immediately answered, "None! I went to play a healing-themed one. It was my friend who took me to play the horror dungeon. What stress could I have? I have such a great boss. It was my colleague's boss who was too mean—I was just accompanying her. I came out after passing two stages."

Xiao Bai always had strong survival instincts.

Whenever she encountered such situations, she would frantically flatter Sister Wang.

Liang Shi just sat there watching with a smile, and once Xiao Bai had survived the "boss's trust crisis," she continued her sales pitch.

Although she was a very close assistant, Xiao Bai didn't know that Liang Shi couldn't really handle horror things. On the contrary, Xiao Bai had always thought Liang Shi was very bold.

After all, she was a woman who wasn't afraid of creatures like snakes.

Let alone intangible ghosts.

Xiao Bai naturally assumed that in this world, there was nothing Liang Shi was afraid of.

So when the system issued this task, Liang Shi thought of coming to play an immersive escape room.

After all, she had already watched horror movies at home before—different experiences feel different.

And she had believed Xiao Bai's words.

Xiao Bai had said that even immersive escape rooms had very healing themes, like the Doraemon-themed one she'd played before, where you just had to find clues in rooms. It wasn't scary at all—even the BGM¹ was very soothing, and the NPCs were only responsible for handing them clues. Some were even quite humorous—it was especially suitable for timid people to play.

She had even patted Liang Shi's shoulder at the time and said, "But Sister Liang definitely wouldn't play something so childish."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi had smiled awkwardly and changed the subject at the time.

Dream Castle, as the name suggested, was a castle. There were five other people doing the dungeon with them, making it a relatively large immersive escape room, semi-puzzle-oriented.

Generally, the puzzle and horror levels were inversely proportional—the more puzzles there were, the less horror there would be.

Dungeons that achieved five stars in both puzzles and horror were very, very rare. After all, they had to consider the market, and extremely intelligent people were a minority.

Most people came to play just seeking thrills and the experience—they didn't want to come and have their IQ insulted.

From its exterior, this castle was quite impressive in scale, comparable to a small villa.

A seven-person dungeon meant there would be solo tasks, but Liang Shi didn't know this.

Among the seven people in their group, there were two men and five women. Including Liang Shi, there were two Alphas, four Betas, and one Omega.

That being Xu Qingzhu.

When everyone learned that Xu Qingzhu was an Omega, all their gazes swept over uniformly, and then they saw Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu's joined hands.

A younger girl said, "Are you two a couple? You match so well."

Liang Shi paused for a moment. "We're married."

That girl's eyes immediately turned into hearts.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu didn't mind. After the seven people entered the castle, the castle doors closed, and then a very eerie mechanical voice sounded in the main hall. This voice was somewhat similar to the system's voice—both had that kind of AI prompt sound with static—and it began to introduce the storyline to them.

It was a very long storyline, but the general idea was that a princess was trapped in Dream Castle, and they needed to pass through seven spaces to rescue the princess. Each space would have clues about the princess.

The space they were currently in was the first one—there were lights, and everything was pink.

This kind of environment gave people a very warm and cozy feeling.

The furnishings here felt like a princess's bedroom, with a bed and cabinets.

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Among them, one was an experienced escape room player who would remind them what to pay attention to inside the escape room. Another was an expert at tearing places apart—when searching for evidence, she would basically turn every corner upside down.

And Xu Qingzhu's good logical ability and powerful calculation skills allowed them to quickly crack codes.

The first three stages were very easy to pass, and they didn't encounter any particularly scary NPCs. Everyone had lowered their guard.

After the third stage ended, they took the elevator to go to the second floor. A girl said, "This is supposed to be a five-star horror dungeon? That staff member must have been lying."

"We can ask him for a refund later," another person said. "Where's the horror in this?"

They were still discussing when suddenly, the lights in the elevator went out. There was no light at all.

The elevator hung suspended, and everyone was startled.

Liang Shi gripped Xu Qingzhu tightly, pulling her directly into her arms, even though her calves had trembled the instant the elevator fell into darkness.

The warm breath from Xu Qingzhu's breathing spread onto her skin. Liang Shi asked in a low voice, "Are you okay?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "I'm fine."

Meanwhile, the people trapped in the elevator immediately started chattering, "Is this the fourth stage?"

"Damn, is this really necessary?"

"We haven't lost anyone, right?"

"No... hey, who tapped my back?"

"I didn't move."

"Neither did I."

Suddenly, a faint glow emanated from a corner of the elevator, and from somewhere came an ethereal voice: "It was me who tapped you."

A childish voice, accompanied by laughter that sent chills down one's spine: "I like you all so much. Can one of you come play hide-and-seek with me?"

"What does this mean?" Liang Shi gripped Xu Qingzhu's wrist, her voice trembling slightly but still holding on. "Is she giving us a clue?"

Although it was her first time playing an escape room, Liang Shi had done her homework beforehand—whenever an NPC appeared, there would definitely be important clues.

The experienced escape room player said, "She's looking for someone to do a solo task."

"The princess is so bored." That childish voice continued to sound in the small space. "Really, no one wants to play with me? Then I'm going to punish you all!"

"Five, four..."

She started counting down, and when she reached 2, that experienced player raised her hand and said she was willing to go.

Then a deep, dark corridor opened up from the side of the elevator, like a mechanism.

Footnotes:

¹ BGM: Short for "background music," commonly used in gaming and entertainment contexts to refer to the ambient music playing during an experience.

Chapter 104-2

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Liang Shi witnessed what a grand production looked like.

During the experience, someone even explained that this was a set that had been used for a TV program's recording, and after changing the story, it was reopened for everyone to play.

The stages after that got harder one after another. Starting from the elevator, it became a turning point—they were often trapped in a single space for an hour.

Throughout this time, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu stayed together. The experienced player who had gone to do the solo task rejoined them at the sixth stage.

By this point, everyone was exhausted.

They had no idea how much time had passed outside. All their phones had been placed in lockers. They couldn't find clues, and the clues they did find couldn't be connected. Everyone was completely confused.

Moreover, they constantly had to face scares while searching for clues.

Especially when Liang Shi picked up a crystal ball while searching for clues in the sixth stage—she then fell into a trap. A wooden panel suddenly opened, and she dropped straight down, landing on a cushioned mat. Her scene immediately switched, while the others were trapped in another space.

The space she was in was completely dark—so dark she couldn't see her hand in front of her face. After entering, she called out for Xu Qingzhu several times, only to find that the other person couldn't hear her voice at all. However, she could hear the others' voices.

She heard Xu Qingzhu calling for her and also heard everyone discussing what kind of space she had entered.

She sat on the cushioned mat, mustered up her courage to reach out and feel around, but touched nothing.

After a while, she heard Xu Qingzhu call out: "Liang Shi, if you're scared, just lean against the wall, close your eyes, and wait for me to come to you."

"That's not possible," the experienced player said. "She needs to do a solo task now. There must be clues on her side waiting for her to find, and then combined with the clues on our side, we can pass this stage together."

Liang Shi answered in a low voice: "I'll try to look around."

The people outside couldn't hear her response either.

Liang Shi didn't particularly like dark environments, but it wasn't to the point of being afraid.

It was because darkness tends to amplify all of one's senses—at such times, whether it was sounds or touches, everything became more sensitive.

It was probably because she had performed so poorly while watching the horror movie that day that Xu Qingzhu thought she was ridiculously timid.

Liang Shi felt it was necessary to correct this mistaken image of herself in Xu Qingzhu's mind.

She slowly braced herself against the wall and stood up. Knowing nothing about escape rooms, she tried to find a light switch on the wall, but there was nothing.

The wall was very smooth—there was nothing at all.

Once her eyes adjusted to the darkness, she could make out a few things here. For instance, in the right corner, there was a reflective mirror.

She didn't know where the light it was reflecting came from.

When she picked up the mirror, she discovered it was one that could light up—the kind of touch-activated makeup mirror commonly seen.

But in this situation, in this environment, a glowing mirror that could show a person's face was even scarier.

At the very least, when Liang Shi turned on that mirror and saw her own face, she thought it was an NPC and was badly startled.

However, by flipping the mirror over, it could be used as a light source. She still prioritized finding the lights first.

She searched along the wall she was leaning against but couldn't find any switch. Then she heard an argument breaking out above.

It was because Xu Qingzhu wanted Liang Shi to stay put, believing there were no usable clues on Liang Shi's side. But the remaining people all thought there must be clues where Liang Shi was, and they needed to coordinate from both sides to pass this stage.

The immersive escape room experience they had purchased was a complete package. The price was very expensive—nearly three thousand per person—with a ten-hour time limit. Only if they couldn't get out within ten hours would the safety passage be opened for them.

At other times, there was no way out provided—unless someone fainted from fright or was scared out of their wits, crying and saying they didn't want to play anymore, waving at the camera and saying the safety word. Then someone would come to escort them out. Once out, it would be considered giving up, and there would be no refund.

So most people wanted to finish playing.

People who came to play this kind of thing generally weren't short on money, but spending several hours in an escape room made people very uncomfortable.

The dark environment, the crowd of people, even the air wasn't fresh.

It made it impossible for people to talk properly.

When they first entered, everyone seemed very easy to get along with, but by the later stages, everyone's patience was nearly exhausted. They just wanted to quickly solve the puzzles, clear the stages, and leave this place.

Xu Qingzhu's suggestion was like asking everyone to stay trapped in the escape room, so naturally, no one agreed.

But Xu Qingzhu said firmly: "If there are clues on her side, we should be able to hear her voice. But right now we can't hear anything, so I'm inclined to have her stay put."

The others all disagreed, chattering away in discussion.

But Xu Qingzhu ignored them and continued searching for clues. Her movements were much faster than before.

Seeing her remain silent, the other players all looked toward the experienced escape room player. In an instant, he became the backbone of this game.

They had been particularly dependent on Xu Qingzhu for the previous stages because her logical reasoning ability was very strong—she could even solve astrophysics problems. So at the beginning, everyone had joked that they'd encountered a top student and didn't need to worry about being unable to solve puzzles. Analyzing logic and organizing clues were Xu Qingzhu's strong suits.

But now Xu Qingzhu had started doing everything alone, and the others all disagreed. The experienced player finally said: "Let's look for a tool that can connect with the other side. There must be one."

She still leaned toward coordinating with Liang Shi from both sides. Then she knocked on the floor panel where Liang Shi had fallen through. "Player Number 4, check if there's any tool on your side that can communicate with this side."

"How are you sure she can hear us?" someone asked.

The experienced player said: "There was a hint when she fell through just now."

The instant Liang Shi had fallen, a voice had sounded here: "Ding-a-ling, you took my crystal ball—caught you! Now your friends can't hear you speak~"

It only said her friends couldn't hear her speak, but it didn't say she couldn't hear her friends' voices.

If it were normal, it would definitely say—You can't communicate anymore!

Xu Qingzhu had also made her judgment based on this.

However, she didn't pay attention to them and continued searching for clues alone.

Meanwhile, Liang Shi in the other space had been searching with that mirror for a long time. She still hadn't found that light, but she encountered an NPC jump scare right in her face.

And it happened one after another.

The first time was a red-clothed NPC, like someone getting married¹, wearing glamorous makeup, with black hair so long it nearly dragged on the ground, hanging upside down from the ceiling.

While Liang Shi was waving the mirror around the walls, the NPC was directly illuminated by the mirror, her face only five centimeters from Liang Shi's.

An extremely intimate in-your-face jump scare.

That mirror showing Liang Shi's own face had been enough to startle her badly, let alone encountering the red-clothed NPC. She was so scared on the spot that her voice cracked when she screamed. Then her hands grabbed wildly and caught a wig.

But the wig was sticky, and she threw it on the ground in fright.

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Very scary.

Extremely scary.

Footnotes:

¹ Red-clothed NPC like someone getting married: In traditional Chinese culture, brides wear red wedding dresses. However, in Chinese horror folklore, ghosts of women who died with grievances (especially brides who died on their wedding day or women seeking vengeance) are often depicted wearing red. This makes the "red-clothed woman" (红衣女鬼) a common and particularly terrifying figure in Chinese horror media.

Chapter 104-3

Liang Shi's heart was about to leap out of her chest. Her mind went completely blank.

It was much scarier than watching the horror movie that day. She had no idea what she should do, where would be safe to go now.

She just wanted to leave.

While she was still in shock, a hand grabbed her foot—it seemed to be a glowing figure.

She had clearly already thrown away the mirror. As long as she didn't look, she wouldn't encounter such terrifying in-your-face jump scares again. But an NPC wearing fluorescent white grabbed her foot and stuffed something near her feet.

Liang Shi didn't feel what the NPC had stuffed there at all—just seeing her figure was enough to make her scream.

The two NPCs' eardrums probably felt like they'd been shattered, but it was only one scream. After the initial fright, Liang Shi stood in place, motionless.

She didn't know what she was supposed to do now.

Until she heard Xu Qingzhu say: "Liang Shi, just find a corner to hide in. I'll come find you."

The foot that had been grabbed by the NPC had already lost all feeling. She numbly moved her body and curled up in a dark corner.

This feeling was very familiar, as if she had experienced it many times before.

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Liang Shi seemed to have fallen into a boundless deep sea, surrounded by endless seawater that was about to engulf her completely.

Memories kept rewinding, tinted with dim, gray colors, like an old movie from the last century playing.

Those forgotten things surged toward her like tidal waves, all stuffing themselves into her mind.

All the memories about darkness.

She had curled up in darkness like this more than once.

Including the original host's memories.

When her luck value had reached 80 before, the system said she had unlocked the usage rights to this body and gave her partial memories. But most of those were bright ones, without too many special things.

The system said most of them were occupied by the original host's powerful consciousness, who was unwilling to give them to her, and the Grievance Management Bureau couldn't forcibly seize the memories.

But now... many dark memories came flooding in.

In a dark basement, she was curled up in a cold corner, with a girl wearing a blue princess dress beside her.

That was Qi Jiao.

Qi Jiao sat shoulder to shoulder with her, hugging her knees, and asked: "Why did your mom send you here?"

She said: "I don't know."

Qi Jiao asked her: "Did you do something wrong?"

She still shook her head: "I don't know."

At that time, she wasn't even as old as Ling Dang was now—she was truly at an age where she didn't understand anything.

She didn't know what she had done wrong, nor did she know why Qiu Zimin had sent her here, using the excuse of giving Qi Jiao another playmate.

After a while, she said in a muffled voice: "I broke a vase that Mom liked."

Qi Jiao said: "It's just a vase. Can't you just buy another one?"

"Mom said I was being naughty and not well-behaved."

"....."

The childish conversation echoed in the dark space, but before long, Qi Jiao was called away.

According to Qi Jiao when she returned later, because there were guests at home, she needed to change into a brand-new, beautiful princess dress, take a nice fragrant bath, and then play piano in front of the guests.

But she played one note wrong.

Too many people had come. She was too nervous, too afraid of making mistakes, yet she still made a mistake.

Originally, no one would have been able to notice, but the visitors were her father's old classmates, and their son was also learning to play piano.

That note was an insignificant one for that piece—even if played wrong, it wouldn't affect anything. Yet that little boy happened to catch it and immediately said loudly after she made the mistake: "You played it wrong!"

This caused her to pause in the middle.

Although she carefully finished playing the entire piece afterward without making any more mistakes.

She was still belittled by her father in front of the guests because of that note, and she could only lower her head and admit her fault.

And her mother's expression was not pleasant either.

That little boy went up and played a piece, flowing and effortless. Afterward, he bragged to Qi Jiao that his piano teacher was the internationally renowned piano master XXX, and that he practiced piano for seven hours every day.

But Qi Jiao's piano teacher was a music department teacher at some university—several levels below that little boy's teacher. Moreover, she had too many classes to take every day: piano, calligraphy, painting, violin, posture training, ballet. The time she could allocate to practicing piano was extremely limited—having one hour was already a luxury.

Besides, she didn't even like piano in the first place.

What Qi Jiao loved most was ballet—wearing a beautiful dress standing on stage, with the lights shining on her, she could dance along with the rhythm.

The teacher who taught her ballet had told her that she had great talent and was born to stand on stage.

But Yang Jiani preferred piano, so Qi Jiao's piano had to be outstanding.

People have no enthusiasm for learning things they don't like. Every time she practiced piano, Qi Jiao forced herself to do it.

Because she didn't want to disappoint Yang Jiani and wanted to make her happy, even though she was practicing something she didn't like, she put in her full effort.

At such a young age, she had too many things to remember.

When she played that note wrong, she had been very anxious.

Chapter 104-4

The belittling on the spot wasn't the worst part. After the little boy's family left, Yang Jiani asked Qi Jiao: "Why did you play a wrong note?"

Qi Jiao said in a low voice: "I'm sorry."

Her voice was trembling, and her body shivered.

But Yang Jiani said: "I don't accept 'I'm sorry.' Jiaojiao, you know I like watching you play the piano."

"I'm sorry, Mom. I won't do it again. I won't slack off anymore," Qi Jiao said.

But she knew she had already done her best. She had put in 120% effort, yet this was still the best she could do.

She also knew that Yang Jiani didn't like hearing that she had no talent, so she could only say it was because she had been slacking and hadn't done her best yet.

While Yang Jiani was scolding her, Qi Xiangui suddenly slapped Yang Jiani across the face.

Qi Jiao was scared, but she still stubbornly stood in front of Yang Jiani. She didn't dare cry and could only call out "Daddy" to try to make Qi Xiangui stop.

But Qi Xiangui, who had just been drinking with his old classmate, wouldn't listen. He even hit her too. Yang Jiani rushed over and held her tightly, shielding her beneath her body.

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Qi Jiao's childish voice echoed in the darkness. She said to the young Liang Shi: "I'm so sad. Why does my dad hit my mom?"

Liang Shi comforted her: "Jiejie¹, things will be better when we grow up."

Qi Jiao asked her with a smile, revealing a small dimple: "What can we do when we grow up?"

Liang Shi sat shoulder to shoulder with her on the cold ground. The basement was also dim, with no light at all.

"When we grow up, we can go to many places. We'll have money, freedom, and a castle."

They kept imagining light and freedom in the darkness.

Qi Jiao said to her: "Then what do you want to do in the future?"

Liang Shi thought about it. "I want to be a teacher."

"Why?" Qi Jiao asked.

Liang Shi: "I want to give warmth to many children. Even if they don't have a happy family, they can still have a happy school life."

"Then I want to be a teacher too," Qi Jiao said. "Let's be kindergarten teachers, okay?"

Liang Shi extended her finger and made a pinky promise² with her.

In that dark basement, they spent many days huddled together for warmth.

Children have no concept of time passing.

It might have been ten days, or it might have been twenty.

Qi Jiao didn't stay for very long because she still had many classes to attend. But Liang Shi spent most of her time in that basement. Almost every day, Yang Jiani would come and ask her: "Will you be good?"

It was like taming an animal—grinding away all her edges, training her until she didn't dare resist or say anything else.

Liang Shi said: "I'll be good. I'll listen to Mom."

But at that time, she missed her eldest brother, missed Qi Jiao, and even missed that unreliable second brother who would take her out to play wildly but would jump into the water without hesitation to save her when she fell in. So when faced with Yang Jiani's words, "Your mom is the person who treats you best in this world," she couldn't repeat them.

But after staying in that place for so long, the only way to get out was to obey.

After who knows how many days had passed, only after she had repeated "My mom is the person who treats me best in this world" nearly hundreds or thousands of times did she finally leave that dark space.

She had once made promises with Qi Jiao in that dark basement—that they would become kindergarten teachers together in the future, that they would go see the ocean together, that they would become explorers together, that they would build a castle.

Qi Jiao had told her: We both have to grow up well. When we grow up, everything will be better.

They had made pinky promises there. Even in the darkness, when they looked at each other, their eyes were filled with light.

Back then, they could embrace each other for warmth.

But in other dark memories, no one embraced her for warmth.

Still in a dark space, the young her was locked in an airtight box. Qiu Zimin said: "Are you ready? Hide-and-seek starts now."

Her small body curled up inside. After waiting for a long time, she kept asking: "Is it over yet?"

But no one responded, and when she pushed on the box lid, she couldn't open it at all.

She was so scared that she wailed inside the box, but no one paid attention to her.

The young her kept calling for Mama, but no one responded.

She was suffocating inside for a long time, unable to breathe fresh air. She felt like she was going to die.

After who knows how long, she finally woke up in a hospital. What met her eyes was stark white. She looked at Qiu Zimin sitting by the bed and asked: "Mama, why didn't you come find me?"

"I went to hide too and forgot about you," Qiu Zimin said.

Qiu Zimin also liked to lock her in cabinets—still complete darkness.

Qiu Zimin said: "This is a game between just the two of us. You can't tell anyone. Mama loves you the most. If others find out, Mama will be sad, and I'll bring others to play the game too. Then you won't be Mama's favorite child anymore."

The young Liang Shi didn't understand the specifics, but she didn't want others to play this game with her.

Because she herself didn't like playing this either.

But when she suggested playing a different game, Qiu Zimin's expression changed: "What do you want to play? Then should I send you to Auntie Jiani's house again to play with Jiejie Qi Jiao?"

And there were countless times she mentioned that if Liang Shi told anyone about this, Qiu Zimin would send her to Yang Jiani's place.

If she told her eldest brother and second brother about this, Yang Jiani would send them there too.

Naturally, Liang Shi wouldn't say anything.

That dark, airtight basement became a nightmare-like existence for her.

She didn't have claustrophobia, but she would subconsciously feel afraid in darkness.

The dark memories that followed belonged to the original host. Liang Shi saw them from an observer's perspective.

The adolescent original host curled up in that dark room. Her favorite spot was behind the door—she had drunk alcohol behind the door, self-harmed behind the door, cried alone behind the door, and slept behind the door.

And there was that dream where the face had never been shown.

In a dark space, the original host lay on a cold bed wearing sheer clothing as thin as cicada wings³. A clear, cold female voice said: "I like to paint things that are broken."

After saying this, a whip came down.

The whip landed on the original host with the sound of whistling air.

The original host's toes curled from the pain. Cold sweat beaded on her forehead. Her face showed coldness and disgust, which only aroused the other person's interest even more.

"Yes, I like that expression of yours," the female voice said. "You'd better keep it that way."

After saying this, another lash of the whip came down.

The original host closed her eyes briefly. Those eyes were cold and without warmth, carrying a detached weariness of the world.

Someone crouched down. She casually pinned up her hair with a hairclip, but her face couldn't be seen clearly at all.

Only her clear, cold voice remained: "Why are you so obedient yet so rebellious? Heh, I like it."

Her long nails, painted bright red, lightly traced across the original host's chin, then suddenly dug in: "They all say Qiu Zimin dotes on her third daughter the most, but why did she send you to me to be a model for a painting? A-Shi."

The way she called "A-Shi" was tender yet carried an icy feel.

The original host's lips moved slightly: "Get lost."

The other person laughed. The sound grew louder and louder, but when her laughter stopped, another whip came down.

At the same time, someone pushed open the door and called out: "A-Shuang."

Footnotes:

¹ Jiejie (姐姐): Chinese for "older sister." It can be used for actual sisters or as a respectful/affectionate term for older girls or women.

² Pinky promise (拉鉤): A childhood gesture of making a promise by interlocking pinky fingers, common in Chinese culture. It's often accompanied by a rhyme about keeping one's promise.

³ Thin as cicada wings (薄如蟬翼): A Chinese idiom describing something extremely thin and delicate, like the translucent wings of a cicada.